ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023

RAJASTHAN

THE 'RIVAAZ' EFFECT

THE BJP'S HIGH COMMAND IN DELHI KEPT LOCAL LEADERS IN CHECK AND RODE TO VICTORY ON A WAVE OF ANTI-INCUMBENCY

By ROHIT PARIHAR



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History was on the Bharatiya Janata Party's side. But that didn't stop Prime Minister Narendra Modi from going all out to secure a win in Rajasthan, a state known to vote for change every five years. That has been the case for the past 25 years and has come to be known as the 'rivaaz effect' due to the custom of chief ministership alternating between the outgoing Congress chief minister Ashok Gehlot and the BJP's Vasundhara Raje. Going by that logic, the chair should have been Raje's this election, but instead it was the PM himself who was the party's face and lead campaigner, investing both time and energy in the desert state to ensure Gehlot did not buck the trend in this political game of musical chairs.

And the blitzkrieg started early. The PM had held a dozen rallies—often in the guise of inaugurations of centrally sponsored projects—in as many months before the election dates were announced on October 9 this year. Post that, he addressed as many as 14 public meetings and led two roadshows in less than a month and a half. In fact, in the final week before the November 25 polling, the troika of the central command—Modi along with Union home minister Amit Shah and BJP national president J.P. Nadda—virtually camped in the state to iron out any last-minute kinks. The focus on tribal-dominated areas yielded positive results, especially in the Mewar region. Besides, the huge turnout at his rallies was a welcome change after the poor mobilisation visible at events, such as the 'parivartan yatra', being helmed by the state organisation thus far.

Meanwhile, Shah, who was initially spending most of his time campaigning in Madhya Pradesh, also shifted focus to Rajasthan after receiving negative feedback on the BJP's prospects in the state. It was he who convinced a number of strong rebels to withdraw their candidature, keeping damage to the minimum. Given that seven of the eight rebels who won in Rajasthan are former BJP leaders, it is not difficult to imagine the impact a string of such rebel candidates could have had.

But the BJP averted that outcome with a major tactical shift in July. Rather than a local warhorse, it made Union minister Pralhad Joshi the election in-charge for Rajasthan to keep the incumbent's personal stake to the minimum. If a sidelined Raje returned to the thick of things just ahead of the election, it was courtesy Joshi, who served as a bridge between the former CM and the BJP high command. In